

that she could handle. While she is now more in control of the situation, paying back her relatives' loans made Maria feel like she had been sent to jail for someone else's crime. Cosigning can make you feel like you are a conspirator to a crime. Both parties share responsibility on a cosigned loan, so be sure your interests are protected.

Parenthood: A Lifetime Responsibility

To be a parent is a commitment for your entire life—not just until your child turns eighteen years old. Does that lifetime responsibility include financial commitments also? When does the parent step in to offer financial assistance? If this assistance is given, does it end up fostering dependency?

Dave was contemplating those questions as he cosigned for his twenty-nine-year-old son's car. His son Tim had survived a messy divorce and now had full-time custody of his two children. Tim had had no success in collecting child support from his ex-wife who had disappeared with a Brazilian man (to Brazil, Tim assumed). Tim had childcare expenses, groceries for three, hockey dues, and tripled electricity and water bills.

Tim called his father almost every month with pleas for help. First, it was money for food, then the phone bill, and then he needed a cosigner for his car. One month, he needed a down payment to start a small business, which would allow him more flexible hours to care for his children. This down payment would be paid back, Tim promised, after the business became profitable.

Dave wondered when it was going to end. He started to tell Tim that he could no longer give him money, but then he didn't have the heart to go through with it when the next request for help came. While he was not happy about giving away so much money, he also couldn't deny help to his son and grandchildren.

